

What are Virtual Machines?

Virtual Machines are computer programs that can run an operating system in a window on your current desktop. These programs create a virtual computer, fooling the operating system into thinking that it's running on a real computer. Although the virtual machine runs as a normal process on your current operating system. You open up the virtual machine just like any other program and boot up the operating system right inside the program. Your current operating system is called the “host” while the operating system you will be running on the virtual machine is called the “guest”.

The virtual machines also emulate the necessary virtual hardware devices and ports like the CPU's, memory, network card, hard drives, USB ports and other devices. These virtual devices are directly mapped to the physical hardware devices of the host. For example, the network interface of your virtual machine will be mapped to the physical network card of your computer system. The operating system you intend to use is installed in a virtual hard drive, the same way as it would have been installed in a real hard drive, without any need to partition your physical hard drive.

You can install most of the operating systems available in the market, on these virtual machines, many options being available on Windows, Mac and Linux systems. But you should know that you can't expect the same seamless experience you would normally get while running the operating system on a real computer. Due to virtual hardware devices being used, it won't be as fast, and playing graphics and processor demanding games would be a bad idea. Basic features and minimal usage of programs is what they are actually intended for.

Why would you use a Virtual Machine?

Virtual Machines can be quite fun to play around with, for the non-geeks too. But what are the reasons you should actually look at while considering using a virtual machine? There are many reasons actually.

Trying out Linux distributions: Every month there are numerous releases and updates to the plethora of Linux distributions, and installing all the interesting ones on your hard drive is definitely a hassle. If there's a certain operating system you are really looking forward to or there's one that has some intriguing features you want to try out, but don't want to go through the hassle of partitioning your hard drive, using a virtual machine is the ideal thing to do. First time users of Linux could install